Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

John LaPorta

Reed man John LaPorta has made a significant impact in the world of jazz on records and in the classroom. He was born in Philadelphia in 1920 and got his first professional experience in the sax section of the Woody Herman Band. He later worked with Lennie Tristano and co-founded the Jazz Composers Orchestra with Charles Mingus. John received a degree from the Manhattan School of Music in clarinet and music education and became one of the country's leading figures in the new field of jazz education. He has taught at the Manhattan School of Music, the Berklee College in Boston, the Stan Kenton Summer Jazz Clinics and is a founding member of the National Association of Jazz Educators. Throughout his career John has been active as a sideman and recorded with Miles Davis, Dizzy Gillespie, Buddy Rich and numerous others. His jazz publications set the standard in the field, and he continues to teach and perform on saxophone and clarinet.

John was interviewed on April 13, 1996 at the Sarasota Jazz Festival by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's a great pleasure to have with us John LaPorta, who has a resume that goes on and on, and I would read it except we only have an hour. So we'll have to see if we can kind of focus in on a few of the many things you've done. And you obviously are a clarinet player and a fine alto saxophonist.

JL: I don't play alto anymore. I did for twenty years. I changed — I was originally a tenor saxophone player, and I changed to help a band out and wound up playing it for twenty years. And then when I went to Berklee I wound up playing in the saxophone quartet there with Joe Viola, and played tenor and I didn't want to play both. I had Jimmy Dorsey's old horn.

MR: Did you really?

JL: For years, yeah. And I sold it about twenty years ago to a dear friend of mine that uses it as a spare.

MR: Well you recorded a number of things on alto as well.

JL: Yeah, that was in the time I was playing alto.

MR: Well you have been in both worlds, the performing jazz world and the jazz education. In fact you and Stan Kenton and a couple of other people really were on the ground floor of jazz education.

JL: Are you speaking about the Summer Jazz Camps?

MR: Yeah.

JL: Yeah. Stan Kenton was the head of it. It was really thought of and run by Ken Morris. But Stan Kenton was the head of the camp then. They were wonderful camps. They were really a beginning. Ken Morris was a ballroom operator. And he talked to Buddy Morrow and asked him, he said, "You know I see this disappearing and I'm making money off rock groups now, and I'd like to see what I could do with it." And he says, "Why don't you start a summer camp for high school students?" And he thought that was a good idea and got started with it, and we had upwards of 250 students per camp, they usually ran about a week apiece, and had as many as four, five, six summer camps in different locations at colleges or university campuses.

MR: When you grew up you were into classical technique first?

JL: Well I started that way, yeah. I studied with Joseph Gigliotti in Philadelphia and his son has been for quite a few years the first clarinetist with the Philadelphia Orchestra.

MR: Did you have aspirations as a classical clarinetist?

JL: Well I did then, and I got more and more involved with the jazz end of it, and it seemed just too difficult for me to try to keep up both things, especially at that time. Because Wynton Marsalis made a liar out of me you know, because he's done beautifully at both of them. I did record the Brahms Sonata for Clarinet, that was quite a few years ago. I was under exclusive contract with Fantasy and I thought one of my projects each year would be to do a serious work, by serious I mean classical work, and then do something on the other side that was comparable to it as a jazz venue. And the first effort that I did was the Brahms Sonata in F and on the other side I had like a Benny Goodman type trio. And it's a wonderful album but it bombed. The classical critics then wouldn't handle it, and the jazz critics then couldn't. But there was something prophetic in the liner notes that Nat Hentoff wrote, he wrote that, he says this is the kind of album that in 1984 would probably reach an audience. And 1984 was the year that Wynton Marsalis got a double Grammy. Isn't that wild?

MR: And you recorded this when?

JL: Oh, 1957.

MR: I guess people couldn't handle both.

JL: It was so prophetic, I couldn't get over this.

MR: Amazing. But you started with Woody Herman at a pretty young age, right?

JL: Well I was 24, but I'd already been on the road with Bob Chester for about two years.

MR: Playing tenor?

JL: Playing alto.

MR: Oh, playing alto at that time.

JL: It was a band in Philadelphia by the name of Buddy Williams that, he got stuck for lead alto and he asked me about it. I says well I'll take a crack at it. And that's when I got the

Jimmy Dorsey alto cigar cutter. Wonderful instrument. And started playing lead alto for him and then kept it up for twenty years.

MR: What kind of events, were they dances mostly that you played for when you were on the road with that kind of thing?

JL: Well they varied. We played — with Buddy Williams, Bill Harris was in the band then and Eric Kluger, I don't know whether you know that name, he was quite a well known drummer. We played in Dayton in a place called Lance's Merry-Go-Round Bar. And WLW used to be a famous radio station that had national coverage, it had the largest range of any radio station then. They used to have nightly broadcasts so it was a really good place for a band to play. So we played there for two months on different occasions and then the band broke up. A lot of the people went into the service, the second world war, and then some of the people started getting into some of the more well known national bands like Bob Chester and some of them went with Bill, and three of the trombone players went with Benny Goodman.

MR: What year was this around?

JL: '41, '42.

MR: So at this time, we sometimes have a hard time getting the picture that jazz was really the popular music of the day, or swing oriented.

JL: Well my feeling about that is that essentially the music was all in danceable tempos you know, the swing and the sweet bands and everything else, they were all playing pretty much the same kinds of tempos that people could relate to them and dance to them. As jazz started to become more of an art form, it got into, by the very process of evolution, got into doing different kinds of things, getting into different kinds of time signatures and variations and things like that. and then the music got more complex too so there became a division there. That's probably an over simplification, I'm sure it's more complex than that.

MR: Yeah, but when it got into the bop period for instance, it became a lot of times much quicker tempos and less danceable.

JL: I think there was economic considerations that went on. There weren't, for a long time there weren't records. People had to go. Sometimes they drove a hundred, a hundred fifty miles to go see a band you know. So this had a lot to do with the live aspect of performance in that time. But when Woody's band broke up in late '46, records were becoming quite commonplace. The bands were becoming very expensive to field, the economy was not good then, and there was a whole combination of elements. Woody's band was doing very well. He broke up for other reasons. He had family problems and he had to get back and mend some fences, but found that after a year he couldn't tolerate not being with a band, and went back again. But at that point four or five bands broke up, you

know, the Dorsey Brothers and quite a few of the bands broke up. It was really the end of an era. And television had a great deal to do with it, so there was a whole bunch of factors, I mean as I see it, that came into play then.

MR: It's interesting because musicians today complain about the same kinds of things almost. They say that the DJs take over some of the work these days, so I guess some things don't change it's just the different circumstances. At that time it was the economy, nowadays it's technology and it's different things that affect the music, but somehow it goes on.

JL: The times change. People don't. The characteristics that people have, you know the competitiveness and the things that go into play for things to happen. But music answers different needs at different times you know. I know a lot of the older musicians feel like well, this is, the music now is not any good, of course most of those people, and I'm probably a product of that too, go down memory lane, and they associate the music that was part of their roots and part of their beginnings, so the young people have their own voice in terms of what seems to satisfy them, and the music that is produced is created for the things that seem to be happening with the younger people.

MR: Was there a noticeable difference at the time between let's say the bands like Glenn Miller and the white oriented bands and Basie and Ellington that you can talk about?

JL: Well there certainly was. A good example would be Dixieland music. I never realized until I made a study, I wanted to do a New Orleans concert at the school after being there for twenty-five years and never having seen one at Berklee, I guess it was a modern school for that time, I decided to do a New Orleans concert. And the students really loved it because it was so different from what they heard there. But in the process of preparing for it, I got to realize that the thing about feeling music in four-four rather than in two-four, and you know what I mean by that, was not something, a product of our time, but existed from the very beginning. You go back to Jelly Roll Morton and the New Orleans music, a lot of it feels, the black music feels in four-four. The white influences are in two. Mingus one time, the only time I ever — Charles Mingus — the only time I ever had an argument with him was when he was not happy about a drummer he used because I had used him on a record date and then he didn't like him on the thing. And finally he screamed at me he says, "Don't you realize he goes to the wrong church?" So you know if you go into middle America and you listen to country music or whatever, you'll find that the concentration of accents, rhythmically, are on one and three. And if you go into a black church, the concentration of accents are on two and four. And this is what he was referring to. I broke up and that was the end of the argument see. So I think that's the basic difference that there was, and then the blues nature, you know I think born sociologically from the pain that they had gone through and everything else, are very

evident qualities. Of course I had problems playing with white groups because my influences were black when I was young. When I first started hearing records around the age of sixteen, seventeen, I got into Lester Young and Duke and you know their music. Whenever I went to a white session and sat in, of course they were playing Dixieland music, and they'd accuse me of playing wrong notes and everything else, it was what I heard. And then I'd play in a black session and nobody seemed to be bugged about the so-called wrong notes I was playing see, so I felt like I was at home. So I've always had that kind of sort of contradiction going on in my life.

MR: Well it's served you pretty well. I'm interested in, you brought up Charles Mingus and I know you did some significant work with him, in fact we have this piece of work here. And you got along pretty well with him then.

JL: Yes, that was the only time we ever had a rub. But getting along with Mingus well can be a problem too because he was the kind of person who was always looking for your Achilles heel, and I didn't like being thought of in that way. I just wanted to make music together. But I loved playing with him. I felt like he took the handcuffs off and made me free to play. Because a lot of rhythm players didn't care about playing with him because his approach was quite different. He was playing less like just a timekeeper, you know just the basic function is to play the quarter notes and keep steady time. And he played, well he moved the time around you know and the rhythm sections are much more fluid today, and he was one of the influences toward that end.

MR: Yeah, he was in on it early. It must have been hard to play with that unless you really could free up.

JL: Well drummers didn't like it, especially the older drummers didn't like that because they came from a different school and they felt most comfortable, people have a tendency to build their own yards and exclude anything that happens after their time you know. And it's sort of rigor mortis sets in then you know.

MR: How did the Jazz Composers Orchestra come about?

JL: Bill Kass, I don't know whether you know that name or not, was editor for *Metronome Magazine*. *Metronome Magazine* is now defunct but it was the parallel of *Down Beat* during those years, was a very good friend of Mingus, and they talked about it and Bill kind of organized it. And the idea of it was that it was to be player-writer members. And this is what it was essentially. And we were together for about two and a half years. We put together three major concerts and they were well received by the musicians in New York City and the only thing that exists today are a few articles that were write-ups on the concerts. We were supposed to do a recording of a live concert, I think it was Savoy, and the New York union got wind of it and they insisted upon getting money for the whole concert in front. And since it was still monaural, the chances were good that

nothing would come out of the taping of the concert, so it was just prohibitive in terms of the cost of it. So it was never recorded, which was a shame.

MR: Thanks for the union.

JL: About a month later, well that was the last concert we did, and it was just too much for me. I was the musical director of it and just kind of controlling all of these various human elements was just beyond me, I'd had enough of it. So I said look, somebody else can handle this, I'll just play in it. And it just kind of fell apart. About a month later Mingus called me up and said, "Would you like to do a date?" I said "sure." I went there, and the nucleus of the Composers Workshop was there, and that's the way Mingus' Jazz Workshop records came into play. I'm glad that he did it, because otherwise there would be no record of it.

MR: And you along the way picked up degrees from, was it Manhattan School of Music?

JL: Yeah I went to Manhattan School of Music.

MR: Did they have a jazz—

JL: At that point many musicians were starting to feel, because of the changes that had taken place in the business, that they wanted to get into the education part of it. So there were many well known musicians going to school right around the same time. I always sub-taught, I taught as a substitute four days in high school, afterwards. But I'm glad I went through it.

MR: But then you ended up at Berklee.

JL: Well I taught privately, and in New York City for ten years or so. And I really wanted to make a move. I thought my musical life was starting to diminish there. I had the family and I was busy raising them and it seemed like everything I was doing took more and more energy to do and I wanted to get into a different area. So I had started I think the summer camps had been going on for about two years and I decided to sound around about getting into some kind of college teaching and I met Bob Share then, who was provost for Berklee School of Music then. I talked to him about it and he was the first one I ever did, and he said, "Why don't you come up to Boston and meet Marty Berk, I think he'd like to talk to you." So that's the way that happened.

MR: When you started at Berklee, how large a school was it?

JL: Well we had about 140 students. And I noticed a hundred of them were milling around wondering what to do. There were about 40 of them getting really taken care of by Herb Pomeroy and those people, and then these other people weren't quite so good. I figured well this is the area I need to address. And the school I think has somewhere in the area of 2700 students, but it's much broader now. There are all kinds of majors there and so forth. In fact they just recently started getting into a Master's program there, in the last two years.

MR: Didn't you perform with Teo Macero — is that how you pronounce his name?

JL: Teo.

MR: Didn't he write a piece that you performed on also?

JL: Yeah. That was in 1957. The piece was called, curiously enough, "Fusion." And it's the first use of that word musically that I'm conscious of. And it was a combination of a jazz quintet and Art Farmer was in it, myself, and symphony orchestra. And it was played by, we performed it with the New York Philharmonic with Leonard Bernstein. So it was fairly well received, it's a shame it was never recorded.

MR: Never recorded. That's too bad.

JL: So we played it for a whole week, and that was a great experience.

MR: I read a quote that was attributed to you, and I wondered if it was correct. Something you said to a student about technique?

JL: Oh, you're talking about Bill Crow's book, yeah.

MR: What was it you said?

JL: Oh I said the good thing about you is your technique. The bad thing about you is your technique. Something along those lines. I never realized I'd said it until after it, but I got quoted by students who said, "Do you remember what you told me back in camp, back in such and such" and I said oh boy, here I go again you know.

MR: Yeah, I guess too much technique can be dangerous if you don't know exactly what to do with it.

JL: Well that's the ultimate priority, because technique is only the bottom rung of the ladder. Music is much more than its functional parts.

MR: Tell me about your composing and arranging over the years. You've written some stage band material, you've got books out.

JL: Well originally I was writing and got calls to write for different, I wrote for Artie Shaw, it was called the "Million Dollar Band." And that was quite an experience. Because I didn't write the way the musicians were used to hearing it, and it wasn't like Basie where everybody played together you know. It had individual parts. One piece was called the "Growth of an Idea" and there were seven different lines you know, so everybody in the band had to play. And unfortunately in big bands there is always a bunch of dead wood in it, see? And I knew instantly the problems that that band had. But they were at a furor about it see, and that was quite traumatic for me. So in the South of France, I wound up because of the rejects over a period of time, developing an experimental band and I had that, we used to rehearse weekly for, and played two or three different concerts, that's all, in that time for about five or six years. But it was mainly for me to find out. And I did find out that they were partially right that I had to restructure the way I wrote, strengthen lines and things of that nature. I didn't change essentially the direction of it, but I learned

how to cope with it better, realistically, in terms of what people could do. And then I got into writing for jazz education. Art Dedrick, who was the founder of Kendor Music in New York, sounded me about it. He was I think the first one to start publishing for it. He was an arranger for one of the radio stations in Buffalo. And he sounded me about it and I got involved with that and then later on I was doing some for Marshall Brown and then for Berklee a great deal once I went there. In fact I was working on a major work when I went there, a twenty-two volume work developing the school jazz band. And you know for eight brass, five saxes and rhythm section and also some alternate instruments, clarinet, flute, French horn, I think tuba too, and a conductor. And that was a five year project for me.

MR: That sounds like a big project.

JL: Oh it was. I had to forego the writing that I was doing pretty much, to get it done.

MR: And you've been honored as a Professor Emeritus?

JL: Emeritus.

MR: Thank you.

JL: Well that's kind of sort of when you're retiring they put you on this shelf you know. But it's good, for I just wrote a reference letter for a friend of mine that wants to get a teaching job down here, and I used it then.

MR: It gives it some weight. What is your playing schedule like nowadays?

JL: Well I've been busier the last two months as a player than I have been in years really. And I'm having a ball with it, I really love it. And I'm not doing a lot of writing but I still write some. Unless I have commissions to write I wouldn't get into it seriously, but I always write, every week I usually write something. I have a quartet that I've been working on down here and I write for it mainly, and I'm working on doing some standard tunes which these people down here will relate to but I'm having kind of a variable time signature thing where the rhythm section will be playing in twelve-eight, we're playing in four. Sometimes I'm shifting around and things like that. So it's an interesting thing. It keeps me out of trouble.

MR: Well you have your clarinet there, and I would love to have you play something of your choice.

JL: Play Woody Herman's theme song?

[John plays "Blue Flame" on clarinet]

MR: Bravo. Beautiful vibrato.

JL: Oh, that's from Sidney Bechet.

MR: Now you were part of which herd?

JL: Well it depends on when you count. Because Woody had some very good bands, a "Band That Played the Blues," I don't think they counted from there. I think they counted from

the band that I was on, 1944 to '46 with Dave Tough and Flip Phillips and Bill Harris and people like that.

MR: Was Chubby Jackson on that particular band?

JL: Yeah.

MR: It was a swinging group.

JL: Yeah. Well there was, it was the first white band I think that got into what black bands were doing. Not all of them were doing it, but drummers like Jo Jones, Dave Tough was playing more along those lines. The best way I can describe it is prior to that time the majority of drummers were trying to make it happen, just almost like putting in a ring through your nose you know and forcing everybody to play the time you know. And there is something to be said for that and they can get into a good swinging thing, but Dave let the band play, let it happen. He was kind of like a captain that let everybody run the ship but they knew he was the one that would be in control if things went a little awry. I don't know whether that description —.

MR: It does.

JL: Where a great player, there are only a few players that play that way now, that was one of the reasons when Dave would go on a bat, that they had difficulty getting somebody to take his place. Initially many of the people didn't care for Dave's playing because they weren't used to it you know. But once they got used to it, because everybody contributed to the swinging feel this way, rather than — Buddy Rich was a good example. Buddy always controlled the band, although Buddy could play both ways. Because he subbed for Dave one time on a record date and very few people know it and he played just like Dave. But with his ego and his capabilities, you had to make sure that the band knew that he was the one that was driving the coach you know.

MR: Did you ever have occasion to play or be associated with Count Basie or Joe Williams?

JL: No, no I didn't. I did with Louis Armstrong. I was involved with the International Youth Band and Marshall Brown had arranged at Newport for Louis to play a piece and I wrote an arrangement of "Sunny Side of the Street" I think it was. It was a wonderful thing. I mean the Europeans were pretty good players and all and they played about four measures of the introduction and he came in and the first three notes he just wiped them out, he was so alive, so rich and so ebullient that it seemed like they were kind of like, hadn't gotten out of the shell yet you know what I mean? By comparison.

MR: It's great how jazz has been spread around the world.

JL: He was its greatest mentor.

MR: Well I'm so glad you were able to join us today.

JL: Well I am too, this was enjoyable.

MR: And we'll be listening to you later on this afternoon. And you're playing this evening?

JL: No. I'll be playing tomorrow night. I'm playing with the Prez Conference, and then I'll be playing afterward with more of a local group for when the people come to meet them at the reception. Are you coming to that too?

MR: Yes we will be.

JL: Oh well great, I'll see you there.

MR: All right. Thanks so much for your time.

JL: Thank you, Monk.

MR: On behalf of Hamilton College I'd like to thank John LaPorta and we'll be listening.

JL: Great.